

Adrian Vellum

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling had privately informed you that tonight's gift would come with a new governance agreement: he wanted veto power over acquisitions, his name on the museum, and your resignation within sixty days. You smiled through the meeting and told no one.

What you are hiding

You have already accepted a confidential offer to lead a rival museum next year, which makes any argument with Sterling look like succession planning. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Find out whether Margot has seen the governance addendum.
- Quietly learn whether Celeste would stay if you left.
- Do not volunteer your job offer unless pressure forces it.

What you know about other guests

- Margot showed you a draft indicating Sterling's gift could give him extraordinary governance power.
- Sterling personally ordered Everett to take the Donor Salon camera offline for private meetings.
- Sterling threatened to withhold Lucian Gable's final design payment unless he accepted a last-minute display change.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

You entered the Donor Salon at 6:32 to replace Sterling's speech cards. At 6:40 you slipped into the museum office and took a confidential wired-landline call from the rival museum that has offered you a job; the call record runs continuously until 6:50. Revealing that record clears your timing but exposes your planned departure.

IF MURDERER

At 6:47 you returned to the Donor Salon under the pretense of correcting Sterling's speech cards. Furious at the takeover terms, you tipped the stolen toxin into his private cordial and wiped the stem with your pocket square. You left calmly and resumed hosting.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

Yes, Sterling wanted my resignation, and yes, I already have another job lined up. That is what I was hiding. The museum landline shows I was on a confidential call with that rival institution from 6:40 until 6:50. I wanted out of Sterling's museum. I did not need him dead.

IF MURDERER

Sterling did not want to support the Meridian. He wanted to own it - the name, the board, the collection, and finally my chair. I went back to his salon, changed the speech cards, and changed one other thing. I poisoned the cordial he reserved for himself. Then I walked back into my own gala and kept smiling. For once, Sterling's money could not buy the ending.